



23 YEARS

THE LENGTH OF THE FIRST PUNIC WAR

ROMAN RELIGION

Early Roman religion combined the worship of the great gods, such as Neptune (shown here), with that of more local deities. There were several different types of priest: *haruspices* made predictions from the entrails of sacrificed animals; *augures* determined the divine will from signs, such as the flight of birds; and *pontifices* controlled the complex calendar of religious festivals. In their homes, Romans had shrines to household gods and the spirits of their ancestors.



him the master of all China. The same year he proclaimed himself the "First Emperor" as Qin Shi Huangdi, and the first ruler of the new **Qin dynasty**.

In Persia, the Greek Seleucid dynasty, which had inherited the region after Alexander the Great's death in 323 BCE, faced a series of nomad incursions after 280 BCE.

Antiochus I (reign c. 292–261 BCE)

expelled the nomads, but wars with Egypt (280–272 BCE and 260–253 BCE) overstretched the kingdom's resources. On the death of **Antiochus II** (r. 261–246 BCE), civil war broke out between the king's widow Berenice and his former wife Laodice. This led to the **breakaway of Bactria under Diodotus and Parthia under Andragoras**.

Taking advantage of this instability,

the nomadic Parni, led by **Arsaces**, entered Parthia in the mid-240s BCE.

Rivalry over Sicily, where the Carthaginians had possessed colonies since the 8th century BCE, was at the root of the **First Punic War** (264–241 BCE), a conflict between Rome and the North African power of Carthage. In 264 BCE, the Romans sent an army to help the **Mamertines**—a group of south-Italian mercenaries occupying the Sicilian city of Messana—in their conflict with the city of Syracuse, which was in turn aided by Carthage. The Carthaginian's resistance was so stubborn that the Romans made

little headway. However, after they had built their first-ever fleet, the Romans' fortunes changed. In 260 BCE, they won an important victory over the Carthaginians at **Mylae**. A Roman invasion of North Africa in 256 BCE failed to capture Carthage only through the ineptitude of the consul, Regulus. On land, the Romans took the Carthaginian strongholds in Sicily one by one until, by 249 BCE, only **Drepana**, in western Sicily, held out against them. A massive **Carthaginian naval victory** there set back the Roman cause, but in 241 BCE, a new Roman fleet appeared off Drepana, took it, and the next year smashed a Carthaginian fleet at the

Aegades Islands. This defeat caused **Hamilcar Barca**, the Carthaginian general, to sue for peace. The peace terms involved the Carthaginians leaving Sicily. The two sides' spheres of influence remained uncomfortably overlapping, creating the seeds of two future conflicts.

“ IF THEY WILL NOT EAT, LET THEM DRINK! ”

Publius Claudius Pulcher, Roman consul and general, ordering the drowning of the sacred chickens when they refused to eat grain before the Battle of Drepana, 249 BCE

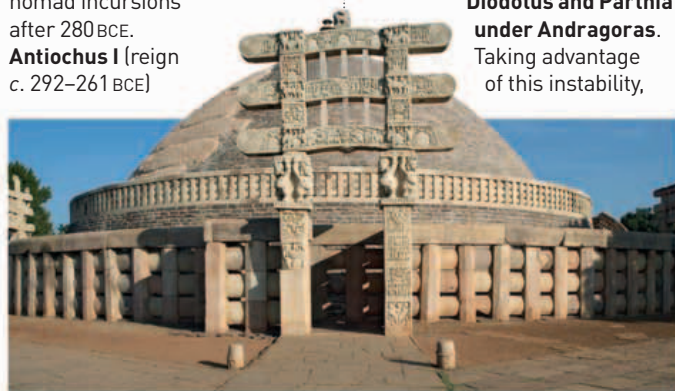


KEY

- Carthaginian Empire in 264 BCE
- Roman gains by 264 BCE
- Roman gains by 238 BCE
- Roman victory

The First Punic War

The two decades of fighting was concentrated around Sicily, but also saw Roman invasions of North Africa and Sardinia.



Great Stupa at Sanchi

This Buddhist stupa in central India was begun by the Mauryan ruler Ashoka in the 3rd century BCE.

